



GoPro cuts jobs again

The action-camera maker chopped about 15 percent of its employees.
<http://dgit.in/GoProjobs>



The Frame

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new law, the 90s would see more high profile hacker arrests. One such arrest was that of prolific hacker Kevin Mitnick. He was charged with obtaining unauthorized access to computers belonging to numerous computer software and computer operating systems manufacturers, cellular telephone manufacturers, Internet



Kevin Mitnick, like many of his fellow convicted hackers, now runs a high profile security firm

Service Providers, and educational institutions; and stealing, copying, and misappropriating proprietary computer software from Motorola, Fujitsu, Nokia, Sun, Novell, and NEC. Mitnick was also in possession of 20,000 credit card numbers.

Hacker<>Cracker/Script Kiddies

What was evident, from the 80s to the 90s, was a clear division within the hacker community. Apart from the benign hackers whose sole objective was to explore, improve, and learn, there was a new, younger group of hackers who were in it for the personal gain. While this divide was pretty evident within the community, popular media and culture viewed any kind of tampering done with any system under the broad umbrella of 'hacking'. This is something that traditional hackers didn't take too well and came up with a new monicker for the other group – crackers. Their intentions varied from personal gain and vengeance to stealing data for criminal purposes, targeting universities, government agencies, and large corporations.

Script kiddies were another break off group that were misrepresented to be hackers by the mainstream media and popular culture. This segment isn't particularly skilled, technology wise, and generally uses ready to use tools to find weak spots in internet connected systems. They don't usually have particular targets and run sweeping attacks to find loopholes. Most attacks reported by the media are of this type.

Globalisation

Enthusiasts all around the world have taken time to learn the skills and get their hands on the equipment necessary to make their presence known. Today, China alone generates more (41%) attacks than the next nine countries combined. Although, to be honest, the target hasn't changed much, with U.S being the most targeted country, and the UAE being a surprise second on the list.

Hacktivism

Many of you might have seen the show Mr Robot. While we're not advocating what the protagonist does, that is pretty much what hacking stands for in today's world. Pretty much any famous hacker group today stands for an agenda. However, the definition of hacktivism, the broad word for agenda driven hacking, in itself is highly debated. For example, take DDoS attacks. Groups like Anonymous, which is the biggest hacktivist group out there now, frequently use it as a method of protest against those they disagree with. It is argued that this particular method is against free speech, at times referred to as the 'poison gas of the internet'.

Questionable methods apart, hacktivist groups have done some pretty significant stuff in recent years.

During the 2009 Iranian election protests, Anonymous played a role in disseminating information to and from Iran by setting up the website Anonymous Iran; they also released a video

manifesto to the Iranian government. During the Egyptian Internet blackout, January 28 – February 2, 2011, Telecomix provided dial up services, and technical support to the Egyptian people. The hacktivist group also announced that they were closely tracking radio frequencies in the event that someone was sending out important messages.

Anonymous and New World Hackers claimed responsibility for the 2016 Dyn cyberattack in retaliation to Ecuador denying Internet access to WikiLeaks founder Julian Assange at their embassy in London.

Harbingers

Over the years, hackers have been denoted as a lot of things – from computer tourists and network voyeurs to dangerous criminals and nihilist anarchists; computer nerds to cyberpunks; public nuisance to catalysts for



A real world Anonymous protest, where anyone can be Anonymous

technology advancement. But amid all these roles, the confusion, and prosecution, there lies a simple answer – hackers are necessary.

Hackers work towards exposing the flaws that lie in the digital systems our lives are completely enmeshed in. Each revolution has its own form and practices. Since today's world is digital, so are today's revolutionaries. Perhaps someday, despite the occasional malpractices and the persistent misportrayal, we will be looking back at hackers as the ones who brought about the change we were waiting for. **4**